

Roads to NOWHERE

The UPA runs into major roadblocks in the mega-crore national highways project

| By Nivedita Mukherjee |

Eight years after it took off as a prominent signpost of India's drive to be one of the world's fastest growing economies, the National Highways Development Programme (NHDP) with its planned network of world-class highways and an investment of Rs 2,20,000 crore is a picture of missed deadlines, policy blips, red-tape, and most importantly, delayed economic benefits to the country. Crucial stretches of the NHDP, including critical corridors meant to cater to high density traffic and

connect state capitals with the Golden Quadrilateral (GQ), are stalled. Either projects have been pushed back, contracts delayed or cut-off dates for bidding extended for lack of interest among contractors. As a result, of the 32,939 km of the NHDP, barely 9,463 km encompassing all its six phases stands ready, with no signs of when the remaining sections will be completed.

The Government now talks of a 2015 target but given the status and pace at which it is moving, even that may remain a dream. According to

the man most closely associated with the project, former Union minister of shipping, roads and transport in the NDA regime B.C. Khanduri, the UPA Government appears to have deliberately neglected the NHDP set in motion in 1998 by former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Khanduri points out that despite a slowdown in the NHDP's pace in the run-up to the 2004 elections, the foundation was firmly in place during his tenure, which included a restructured National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), geared to implement the mega



POOR QUALITY OF ROADS AS THIS CAVED-IN SECTION OF THE AHMEDABAD-VADODARA EXPRESSWAY SHOWS HAS DELAYED THE NHDP

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